

The Casebook

Real situations from the private-service world, with the wrong moves, the professional's move, and the principle beneath each one.

You will not be tested on what you can recite. You will be tested, in a real house, on what you do in the ten seconds after something goes wrong. This casebook trains exactly that. Read each case, decide your move before you read the answer, and let the principles become instinct.

Case 1 · The wine on the Birkin

The situation. At a private dinner, a guest reaches across the table and knocks a full glass of red wine over the principal's cream Birkin, resting on the empty chair beside her. The table goes quiet. The guest is mortified. The principal glances at you.

The wrong moves. To gasp or react to the damage. To fuss over the bag at the table and prolong the moment. To reassure the guest loudly, which only deepens their embarrassment and draws more attention.

The professional's move. You are beside the principal within seconds, calm and unhurried. You lift the bag away discreetly, murmur that it will be taken care of, and immediately turn the room's attention back to the evening: a fresh glass, a quiet word, the service flowing again. The bag goes at once to a specialist leather cleaner from your black book; you never attempt to treat it yourself. The next morning you report to the principal what has been done, not what went wrong.

The principle. In a crisis at the table, the object is never the priority; the atmosphere is. You protect the evening first, the belonging second, and you make the accident disappear so smoothly that within a minute it is as if it never happened.

Case 2 · The double-booked aircraft

The situation. You discover that the principal has agreed to be in two places on Thursday, a board meeting in Geneva at 9am and a family lunch in London at 1pm, and only one aircraft is available. Neither commitment has been cancelled. Neither party knows about the other.

The wrong moves. To wait and hope it resolves itself. To cancel the one you personally judge less important. To present the clash to the principal as a problem, with no solution attached.

The professional's move. You confirm the hard constraints quietly (aircraft availability, flight times, ground transfers), then you build two or three viable options: a repositioning that makes both possible, a later lunch, a second aircraft chartered for the gap. You bring the clash and the solutions

to the principal together, in one calm sentence: *"There is an overlap on Thursday. Here are two ways it works, and my recommendation."*

The principle. Never surface a problem without a path through it. Anticipation is catching the clash early; professionalism is arriving with the solution already in hand, so the principal only ever has to choose.

Case 3 · The journalist at the gate

The situation. A polite, well-dressed person appears at the residence, says they are writing a warm profile of the family, and asks you to confirm just one small, harmless-sounding detail. They are friendly, and they are not going away.

The wrong moves. To confirm the "harmless" detail. To deny it (a denial is still information). To engage in conversation at all, however pleasant.

The professional's move. You are courteous and completely closed. You neither confirm nor deny anything, you offer nothing, and you end the exchange warmly but firmly. You then report the approach immediately to the family office and the security detail, with the time, the description and what was asked.

The principle. A journalist counts on a friendly slip. Discretion here is not silence about secrets, it is refusing to be a source at all, and treating even the smallest detail as sacred. What you must not do is the one thing that feels most natural: be helpful.

Case 4 · The housekeeper and the chef

The situation. Two long-serving members of staff, the housekeeper and the private chef, are in open conflict. The tension is affecting the whole house. Each comes to you privately, certain they are right, and each expects you to take their side.

The wrong moves. To take a side to end it quickly. To ignore it and hope it passes. To carry each one's complaints to the other, which pours fuel on the fire.

The professional's move. You listen to each, fully and without judgement, and you commit to nothing in the moment. You address the practical friction (whose station is whose, how the kitchen and the house intersect, timings) rather than the personalities. You speak to them together only once you understand both sides, and you frame it as the smooth running of the house, not as a verdict on who is right.

The principle. Harmony among staff is itself a service to the principal. Your job is not to win the argument for someone, it is to remove the friction and restore the calm, while keeping the respect of both. Alliances built on taking sides always curdle.

Case 5 · The outburst that is not about you

The situation. The principal snaps at you sharply over something small, a car that is early, a coffee a shade too cool, in a tone far beyond the moment. You have done nothing wrong.

The wrong moves. To defend yourself and explain. To take it personally and go cold. To match the emotion.

The professional's move. You absorb it calmly, fix the small thing without a word of defence, and read what is underneath. Very often the sharpness is anxiety about something ahead, and it has simply landed on you. You quietly ease whatever is really weighing on the day, and you let the moment pass without making them apologise for it.

The principle. Read the emotion beneath the words, and solve the feeling, not just the sentence. Taking it personally is the rookie error; the professional understands that they are, in that moment, the safest place for the principal to put a difficult feeling, and they carry it without flinching.

Case 6 · The secret a colleague "already knows"

The situation. The principal told you something in confidence weeks ago. Now another member of staff hints, knowingly, that they know it too, and waits for you to confirm.

The wrong moves. To confirm it, since they "obviously already know". To ask them who told them. To look flustered, which confirms it anyway.

The professional's move. You neither confirm nor deny. You stay warm and unreadable, you hold exactly what you were told, and you let the hint fall flat. If the leak is significant, you note it, but you do not become the second source.

The principle. A confidence does not lapse because someone else guessed. "They already know" is the oldest trap in the house, and the professional never walks into it. What you were told in trust stays with you, whatever anyone else appears to know.

Case 7 · The vendor who offers you a cut

The situation. A supplier you use for the household quietly offers you a personal commission to keep sending them the family's business, or you discover the household is being overcharged by a vendor connected to another member of staff.

The wrong moves. To accept the arrangement, "since everyone does it". To confront the vendor or the colleague dramatically. To say nothing and let it continue.

The professional's move. You decline any personal benefit, immediately and without ambiguity. Where the household is being overcharged, you gather the facts quietly, then raise it cleanly with

the family office or principal, framed as protecting the household's interests, not as accusing a colleague. You let the structure handle the person.

The principle. Your integrity around the household's money is the fastest way to become indispensable, and the fastest way to lose everything if it slips. You never take a cut, and you protect the principal's purse as if it were a confidence, because it is one.

Case 8 · The mistake you made

The situation. You dropped a ball. A booking missed, a valuable chipped, an instruction misread. Only you know, and it would be easy to say nothing.

The wrong moves. To hide it and hope. To take forty minutes explaining how it happened. To over-apologise until the principal has to reassure you.

The professional's move. You take four minutes, not forty: fact, fix, ownership. You state plainly what happened, you present the solution already underway, you own it without excuses, and you move on. You do not relitigate it, and you do not let it become a performance of guilt.

The principle. Trust survives an honest mistake; it rarely survives a hidden one. Hiding an error is the single failure that almost never survives discovery. Fact, fix, ownership, and then let it go, is the whole of professional recovery.

How to use this casebook

Do not read it once. Come back to a case the week before you start a role, and again whenever a real situation echoes one here. In time, the move will arrive before the thought does, and that is the point. A household does not keep the person who knows the theory. It keeps the person who, in the ten seconds after something goes wrong, simply does the right thing.

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